

Foreword

Today, telecommunications is a global market-place, with ever-increasing demand for traditional telephony and exponential growth in new areas as the dataware builds up. The technology we use and the customers we serve are becoming more sophisticated — but no matter how global networks become they still require a local link or access network to gain access to it.

The days when local access was provided exclusively over copper pairs with a bandwidth capability little more than that required for voice transmission are long gone. Today, we provide access by satellite, radio, fibre and copper with greatly enhanced bandwidth capabilities. BT has an extensive fibre access network across the UK, and its capabilities are constantly enhanced through new technologies, like SDH or xDSL.

We need to deploy a wide range of access mechanisms in order to meet the demands of our customers, from major global business players to single line residential customers, at the lowest possible costs. Our existing copper network, enhanced through xDSL technology, will form the basis for meeting mass-market demands for voice and data connections.

This year we have introduced HomeHighway which enables customers to have Internet access at the same time as telephony over the same copper pair using ISDN technology. At the low bandwidth end of the market we will continue to be cost competitive by using one copper pair to serve up to four customers with a 56 kbit/s modem-ready telephony channel. HDSL technology already enables us to provide 2 Mbit/s over copper. From next year we will be able to offer video-on-demand access to service providers using ADSL technology. Although these technologies open the door to 30-fold bandwidth growth to the home or office in the next few years, they surely are not the end of the story.

By deploying radio and fibre as well as satellite access we already provide customers with the high levels of bandwidth and quality they require. In addition, there are a range of emerging technologies awaiting development and application that offer exciting possibilities for ever higher bandwidth, lower cost and increased functionality in the new millennium.

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